

CLOCKING OUT

Written by
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FADE IN:

INT. FACTORY FLOOR - EVENING

Machinery CHURNS and CLANKS in a deafening rhythm.

MIKE, a simple factory worker in an orange safety vest and earmuffs, stands at a conveyor belt. He guides an overhead funnel to line up with the containers passing below, filling each one with a white powder. Mike looks tired.

After filling several containers, his attention is drawn to the door, where he can just make out a conversation over the noise.

JERRY, one of Mike's coworkers, is being forcefully escorted out of the building by two heavily armored SECURITY GUARDS. One of them carries a cardboard box of Jerry's belongings.

JERRY

C'mon, guys, this is ridiculous!

GUARD #1

Chapter 18, Section 3 of the contract. You missed too much work, and you're being charged with desertion.

JERRY

Desertion? I'm a factory worker, not a damn soldier. All I do is put the labels on the boxes!

Jerry wrestles himself free and turns around to face the guards.

JERRY (CONT'D)

I already told Mr. Sterling I had to miss three days. My father died. I had to be with my brothers. Guys, come on, you understand, right?

Ignoring him completely, Guard #2 turns Jerry back around and keeps pushing him toward the door.

GUARD #2

You have been terminated from your position at MegaCorp and are no longer allowed on the premises.

JERRY

Wait, please don't do this. I have people relying on me--

Just before he's shoved out the door, Jerry glances at Mike, who's been staring this entire time. Mike slowly turns away, looks down at his containers, and keeps filling.

The factory floor quickly settles back into its monotonous routine after the show.

MR. STERLING, a middle-aged man in a tracksuit, jogs down the line, observing the workers. He stops at Mike.

MR. STERLING
Make sure you're filling those all the way, kid. And we're going to need an extra batch, since we were short yesterday. Thanks, champ!

Before Mike can reply, he's already jogging off down the line.

MIKE
Yes, sir.

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Mike exits the building, bags under his eyes. Fluorescent lights buzz overhead. Half the lot is empty.

He walks toward the street.

EXT. SIDEWALK - CONTINUOUS

A homeless encampment lines the block. One of the tents is selling trinkets laid out on a blanket. Mike hands the woman running it some cash and takes a small collar with a bow on it.

He makes his way to the subway entrance.

INT. SUBWAY CAR - NIGHT

Mike stands in an overcrowded train, shoulder to shoulder with the other riders, all of them swaying with the motion of the dimly lit car.

INT. APARTMENT BUILDING - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Mike walks up to his apartment door. As he fumbles with his keys, the door next to his opens, and MARIANNE, an older woman, steps out.

MARIANNE
It's nearly eleven. This is what,
three weeks straight of them
working you to death?

Mike gives her a quick glance and smiles through his
exhaustion.

MIKE
It's alright. You know I could use
the hours. Besides, you know what
we're making. That equipment can
save lives. I don't mind staying
late for that.
(beat)
How's Lucy been?

MARIANNE
(sighing)
Lucy is okay. Lazy as ever. She
just lays about all day, y'know? I
need to find someone willing to
take her on walks. She's getting
fat!

MIKE
(smiling)
We'll take her to work. She can
walk on the conveyor belt!

MARIANNE
(laughing)
Oh, she'd love that. Until she gets
stuck in a box and shipped off to
Canada, or wherever those things
go.
(beat)
But I really am worried about you.
This is unhealthy.

MIKE
I know. If they ask again tomorrow,
I promise I'll tell them no, okay?

Marianne looks down and sighs, then nods silently.

LUCY, an orange house cat, appears beside Marianne in the
doorway.

LUCY
Meow.

MIKE

Hey, there you are! Look what I got
you.

Mike kneels in front of the cat, pulls the bow collar from
his pocket, and fastens it around her neck. Lucy starts
purring and rolling on the floor as Mike stands back up.

MARIANNE

(hand over her heart)
Thank you, Mike. She looks
adorable.

MIKE

Hopefully she likes it! There's a
space for you to write her name,
just in case she gets lost.

(beat)

I should get to sleep. Got work in
the morning. Goodnight, Marianne.
Goodnight, Lucy!

LUCY

Purr.

Marianne scoops up the cat and heads inside. Mike heads into
his own apartment.

INT. FACTORY FLOOR - MORNING

Mike walks into work to find a crowd gathered around one of
the stations.

Walking over, he sees the nameplate reading "JERRY" being
removed, and an automatic labeling machine being installed
in its place.

The machine WHIRS to life and successfully labels several
boxes. The crowd murmurs.

JEREMIAH, a large man carrying a crate, speaks up from the
crowd, drawing everyone's attention.

JEREMIAH

They replaced him with a machine!

He sets the crate down and stands on it.

JEREMIAH (CONT'D)

Our friend lost his livelihood
yesterday, and so did many others
before him.

(MORE)

JEREMIAH (CONT'D)
Aren't you all tired of how they
treat us? Like we're disposable?

The crowd nods in agreement.

JEREMIAH (CONT'D)
The truth is, we don't need them.
They need US! How much longer until
every one of us is replaced? I say
enough is enough. We will show them
that without us, they have NOTHING!

The group applauds and cheers, fired up by the speech, and
begins talking among themselves.

WORKER #1
Are we going on strike?

WORKER #2
How does this work?

Mr. Sterling power-walks onto the factory floor, two heavily
armed guards behind him.

MR. STERLING
What is all this? All of you, back
to work. NOW!

The crowd slowly disperses under the watchful eyes of Mr.
Sterling and his guards, whispering to each other as they
go. Jeremiah picks up his crate and heads toward the
warehouse, stopping by Mike on the way.

JEREMIAH
(whispering)
Tomorrow, we're all going on
strike. You in?

MIKE
(whispering)
Yeah, of course I'm in. You can
count on me!

Jeremiah smiles and gives Mike a hearty slap on the back,
then moves on. Mike shuffles over to his station and gets
back to work.

INT. MIKE'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A silent apartment. The mechanical flip clock on the table
FLIPS to 12:05.

The door opens, and Mike walks in looking dead tired. He staggers over to the couch and yawns before collapsing onto it, passing out almost immediately.

INT. MIKE'S APARTMENT - DAY

The silence is broken by Mike rolling off the couch and hitting the floor with a THUD. The flip clock FLIPS to 9:20.

Mike groans and slowly picks himself up, stretching as he goes. With one eye open, he walks past the table and makes it halfway down the hall -- then stops. He turns slowly, walks carefully back to the clock, picks it up, and looks at the time.

MIKE

Oh, crap.

He drops the clock, gathers his things, and rushes out the door as fast as he can.

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - DAY

A picket line of STRIKERS stretches across the parking lot behind a makeshift fence in front of the factory. CHANTING and ARGUING fill the air between the workers and the guards lined up at the main entrance.

Mike can barely keep his eyes open. Yawning nonstop, earmuffs already on, he walks right past the strikers and into the factory without registering a single word.

INT. FACTORY FLOOR - DAY

Mike reaches his station and, still half asleep, flicks on all the switches and buttons to power up his equipment.

He puts on his vest and takes his position -- then notices that the station in front of him is empty. Confused, he turns to look at the next one. Also empty. He steps into the middle of the aisle and looks down the length of the line. Completely deserted.

MIKE

What?

Footsteps approach from the entrance. Mike turns to see Mr. Sterling and his guards, along with EVELINE, a woman in a fancy dress and a hard hat.

MR. STERLING
There he is! My boy, Nick!

MIKE
It's actually Mike.

MR. STERLING
That's what I said. Listen, I
always knew you were my favorite!
Of course you'd know better than to
take part in some "strike." Those
ingrates.

Mike's eyes go wide with realization. He hesitates before
answering his boss.

MIKE
Yeah... of course. You're right.

MR. STERLING
Of course I'm right. And hey, kid--

Mr. Sterling gestures toward Eveline.

MR. STERLING (CONT'D)
This is the CEO of MegaCorp. She
wants to talk!

EVELINE
It's a pleasure to meet you...
Mike, was it?

She extends her hand for a handshake. Mike, taken aback,
shakes it.

MIKE
That's right, ma'am. I work at
station 32D, just over there.

He gestures toward the empty station behind them. Eveline
doesn't even look.

EVELINE
How would you like a promotion?
"Head of the Factory Floor"!

MIKE
That would be great, but--

EVELINE
Yes, very great. It's a role
perfectly suited for you. All you
have to do is...

She gestures toward the main entrance. Mike steps over and looks out the window at all his coworkers outside.

EVELINE (CONT'D)
Convince them to come back to work.
Be an example to these lost sheep.

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - MINUTES LATER

Mike steps out into the parking lot holding a megaphone, a badge pinned to his vest that reads "HEAD OF THE FACTORY FLOOR." The crowd quiets as everyone turns to face him.

MIKE
(through megaphone)
Uhh, hey, everyone--

The megaphone is way louder than expected. Everyone winces. Mike lowers it.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Hey, everyone. How's it going?

A couple of people yell from the crowd.

STRIKER #1
What are you doing, man?

STRIKER #2
Traitor!

MIKE
Have you guys met Eveline? She's really nice, and, uh... she wants you all to come back to work.

The yelling intensifies, and they start BOOING him. One worker throws his sandwich, which hits Mike square in the face. He wipes the condiments off.

MIKE (CONT'D)
C'mon, guys, that's a waste of food!

STRIKER #1
And you're a waste of space!

The crowd grows rowdier as Eveline's guards escort Mike back inside. He glances back and locks eyes with Marianne, near the front of the picket line, looking concerned. Mike looks away and heads inside.

INT. TOP FLOOR HALLWAY - DUSK

Mike sits by a window, looking down at the strikers still holding the line below, writing ideas for ending the strike in a notebook. He glances at a clock on the wall. It's getting late.

MIKE

This will have to do...

He gets up and walks to the big boardroom doors. He's about to go in when he hears YELLING from the other side. Mike presses his ear to the door and listens...

INT. BOARDROOM - CONTINUOUS

Eveline, Mr. Sterling, and a few other EXECUTIVES huddle around a large desk.

MR. STERLING

(yelling)

This is bad! We lost an entire day's production. We're already cutting it close as is--

A CRACK OF THUNDER interrupts the impromptu meeting. Rain begins to fall outside.

EVELINE

Oh, good. That should weed out at least some of them. And calm down, Sterling, there's no need for that. But we do need them back in here. Now.

EXECUTIVE #1

We could lie. Give in to their demands, then backtrack later. We can't afford to have those defect reports leaking before we get all the product out the door.

EVELINE

Normally I'd agree, but we're months away from breaking even. We can't afford another strike in that time. And we can't afford to just wait them out, either.

The room goes quiet as everyone searches for a solution. Eveline grows angrier and angrier.

EVELINE (CONT'D)

These miserable rats. Thinking they know anything about the real world. They know nothing. Not even that if they delay any longer, none of them will have a job anymore.

(beat)

We might have to do this the old-fashioned way. GUARDS!

She throws open the doors. Mike stumbles back, caught. She doesn't care. A few heavily armed guards fall in behind her as she strides down the hall. Mike chases after them.

MIKE

Hey! What's going on? You appointed me negotiator. I should be involved!

INT. FREIGHT ELEVATOR - CONTINUOUS

Mike squeezes into the freight elevator with them.

EVELINE

Force, Mr. Mike. We will keep them in line with force. It's sad that they've put me in this position.

Mike's eyes go wide with shock.

MIKE

What? You can't do that! Those are my friends!

EVELINE

Oh, hush now. If everyone complies, no one will be seriously hurt. It's going to be your job to convince them to come back in. If anyone gets injured, that's on you. So do your best to get them back in here.

The elevator reaches the ground floor. The small army marches toward the entrance, and Mike walks with them, his mind racing.

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - EVENING

Rain falls steadily. The picket line has thinned, but a stubborn crowd remains. The guards surround the strikers as Eveline addresses them through a megaphone.

EVELINE
(through megaphone)
You will ALL return to work. Anyone
who doesn't do so voluntarily will
be made to.

She nods at the guards, who ready their nightsticks. The crowd looks wary. After a long moment, a few start to walk toward the entrance -- when a voice calls out.

MARIANNE
Wait! Everyone!

Marianne makes her way to the front of the line and addresses the crowd.

MARIANNE (CONT'D)
We can't let them bully us into
submission. They HAVE to listen to
us. We just need to hold out a
little longer! This egregious
display only shows how desperate
they've become.

EVELINE
Shut up! Why is it so hard to just
do what you're told?

Eveline points a guard toward Marianne. He approaches her and raises his baton above her head, but Marianne just stares at Eveline, unmoving. The crowd is still. Eveline is shaking with anger.

EVELINE (CONT'D)
(yelling)
Get rid of her!

She signals the guard to swing. He winds up -- but out of nowhere, Mike jumps in front of the baton.

MIKE
Hold on! Whoa, wait!

He holds his hands up and faces Eveline.

MIKE (CONT'D)
I won't let you hurt my friend.

Mike turns to face the crowd.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Everyone, Marianne is right. We
need to stand up for ourselves.
(MORE)

MIKE (CONT'D)
I'm sorry I didn't see that sooner.
I know what they're doing here. She
can't afford to hurt any of you.

Mike turns back toward Eveline and points at her.

MIKE (CONT'D)
(shouting)
Everyone! She's been using us. All
of us. She doesn't care about this
place, and she doesn't care about
any of you. Why do you think she
came down here herself? Why bring
guards? Why bring weapons?
(beat)
Because they're scared. They need
us more than we need them.

The crowd starts to shift. Workers look at each other. Their
fear begins turning into anger.

MIKE (CONT'D)
I heard them talking upstairs.
They're desperate and behind
schedule. They can't finish without
us.
(beat)
This whole place stops without us.

Eveline steps forward, furious.

EVELINE
That's enough! Arrest him!

The guards hesitate.

MIKE
Look around! There are more of us
than there are of them. If we give
in now, nothing changes. Tomorrow
it'll be someone else. Then someone
else. Jerry. Marianne. Me. You.

Marianne steps up beside him.

MARIANNE
He's right.

A few more workers step up to join them. Then a few more.
Soon it's a wall of people.

EVELINE
Guards! Listen to me!

But this time, they don't move.

MR. STERLING
Ma'am... maybe we should
reconsider--

EVELINE
No. I will not be spoken to this
way by animals!

She turns toward the group and speaks directly to Mike.

EVELINE (CONT'D)
Stop this! Just do what you're
told!

Mike pauses a beat. Then he tears off the "HEAD OF THE
FACTORY FLOOR" badge and drops it on the ground.

MIKE
I'm done blindly following orders.
Why don't you tell everyone what it
is we're doing here?

The crowd murmurs, looking at each other in confusion.

STRIKER #1
We make medical supplies.

STRIKER #2
We help people!

EVELINE
That's not their concern!

MIKE
No. It is.
(beat)
There's a defect in those machines.
And you knew it. You had us push
them out anyway.

STRIKER #1
The reports... they told us to
ignore them...

The crowd shifts again -- not just angry now, but disturbed.

MIKE
We didn't know. But they did.

All eyes turn to Eveline.

MIKE (CONT'D)
(quietly)
We thought we were helping.

Silence.

EVELINE
People needed those machines!
Delays cost lives too!

She looks around at the crowd frantically.

EVELINE (CONT'D)
Enough! Guards, put an end to this
already!

The guards hold for a moment, still facing the workers. Then one lowers his baton. One by one, the others follow, lowering their weapons. The crowd turns to stare at the CEO.

A beat.

Eveline lets out a frustrated grunt and tries to run, but her own security catches her after only a few feet.

EVELINE (CONT'D)
Let go of me!

GUARD #1
(quiet, conflicted)
...Sorry, ma'am. I can't do that.

In the chaos, Mr. Sterling tries to sneak away as well, but Jeremiah and a few other strikers intercept him.

JEREMIAH
Going somewhere?

EXT. COMPANY PARKING LOT - LATER

Eveline and Mr. Sterling are loaded into police cruisers. Officers take statements from the strikers. Mike finishes talking with a DETECTIVE, who walks away.

STRIKER #2
Hey, great job, man!

Mike just nods as a few strikers pass by, one giving him a pat on the back. Marianne walks up.

MARIANNE
They cleared me to go home. How
about you?

MIKE

I'm good to go too.

Light spills across the lot as the sun peaks over the horizon. It's dawn.

MARIANNE

All night at the factory? That might be a new record!

MIKE

For you, maybe. I'm used to sunrises around here.

The two chuckle.

MIKE (CONT'D)

C'mon, let's go home. I owe Lucy a couple of head pats.

Mike and Marianne walk off the lot and down the street, talking the whole way.

FADE OUT.

THE END